this basic democratic principle, but somehow conclude from it that a single party or a single leader should monopolise all power. In a curious political alchemy, populists manage to base a totalitarian pursuit of unlimited power on a seemingly impeccable democratic principle. How does it happen?

The most novel claim populists make is that they alone truly represent the people. Since in democracies only the people should have political power, and since allegedly only the populists represent the people, it follows that the populist party should have all political power to itself. If some party other than the populists wins elections, it does not mean that this rival party won the people's trust and is entitled to form a government. Rather, it means that the elections were stolen or that the people were deceived to vote in a way that doesn't express their true will.

It should be stressed that for many populists, this is a genuinely held belief rather than a propaganda gambit. Even if they win just a small share of votes, populists may still believe they alone represent the people. An analogous case are communist parties. In the UK, for example, the Communist Party of Great Britain (CPGB) never won more than 0.4 per cent of votes in a general election,[9] but was nevertheless adamant that it alone truly represented the working class. Millions of British workers, they claimed, were voting for the Labour Party or even for the Conservative Party rather than for the CPGB because of 'false consciousness'. Allegedly, through their control of the media, universities and other institutions, the capitalists managed to deceive the working class into voting against its true interests, and only the CPGB could see through this deception. In like fashion, populists can believe that the enemies of the people have deceived the people to vote against its true will, which the populists alone represent.

A fundamental part of this populist credo is the belief that 'the people' is not a collection of flesh-and-blood individuals with various interests and opinions, but rather a unified mystical body that possesses a single will – 'the will of the people'. Perhaps the most notorious and extreme manifestation of this semireligious belief was the Nazi motto 'Ein Volk, ein Reich, ein Führer', which means 'One People, One Country, One Leader'. Nazi ideology posited that the *Volk* (people) had a single will, whose sole authentic representative was the *Führer* (leader). The leader allegedly had an infallible intuition for how the people felt and what the people wanted. If some German citizens disagreed with the leader, it didn't mean that the leader might be in the wrong. Rather, it meant that the dissenters belonged